In addition, the company promised to “aid, assist, and defend” the king of Ava and Pegu against all enemies. The treaty succeeded in promoting neither friendship nor alliance. Deeply suspicious of the intentions of the East India Company, Alaùngpayà launched a raid on the Cape Negrais settlement on October 6, 1759, massacring Captain William H. Southby and the local agents of the East India Company. The attack was in retaliation for alleged British support to the Mon rebellion of 1758. Contact between the East India Company and the Konbaung dynasty ceased in 1761 following the cessation of hostilities and would not resume until the Arakan border incidents of 1794.

THE ANNEXATION OF ARAKAN AND ANGLO-BURMESE TENSIONS

As the British and French were occupied fighting each other across the Bay of Bengal, 35 years went by before the East India Company sent another mission to Burma. The next contact between the British and the Burmese occurred as a result of the Burmese annexation of the kingdom of Arakan in 1785 following a brief campaign led by Crown Prince Bodawpaya. This created a common border between the British and the Burmese along the Bengal-Arakan frontier. The Burmese occupation of Arakan was extremely repressive, especially in terms of the conscription of forced labor. A levy to expand the irrigation system around the town of Meiktila in 1795 set off open rebellion in Arakan, assisted by armed support of three Arakanese chiefs now living in Chittagong. The mutual distrust created by the presence of Arakanese rebels operating from within British territory created increased border tensions. Burmese troops would chase fleeing Arakanese rebels and refugees into the neighboring British Bengal claiming “the right of hot pursuit” under their own international custom, while the British denied the existence of such a right according to international law. The Burmese threatened to invade if the British failed to curtail the rebel incursions from their territory. When the Burmese commander offered to withdraw his forces if the three Arakanese chiefs were handed over, British General Erskine complied and the incident ended without further conflict.